Despite these challenges, there are compelling reasons for IOs to counter populist narratives using direct appeals to ordinary citizens. IOs are staffed by mission-driven leaders and bureaucrats committed to upholding the international order and ensuring the organizations' survival (Chwieroth 2015; Honig 2018). Public support is essential for maintaining legitimacy, and IOs often rely on it to fulfill their mandates successfully (Dellmuth 2018; Tallberg and Zürn 2019; Dellmuth and Tallberg 2023). Moreover, softening public hostility could reduce the costs for populist leaders to cooperate with IOs, potentially encouraging more constructive engagement.

Importantly, social media provide a cost-effective means for IOs to engage directly with citizens, especially in low-salience issue areas where public familiarity with IOs' roles and operations is limited. This baseline knowledge gap offers IOs an opportunity to influence perceptions by portraying themselves as less elitist and more aligned with ordinary citizens' interests. Countering populist rhetoric on platforms like Twitter is thus a pragmatic strategy for IOs, consistent with their adaptive responses to other political shocks (Ecker-Ehrhardt 2018b). In short, rhetorical engagement has limited downsides given how cheap it is to reach out to public audiences on social media.

We specifically propose that IOs combat populist narratives by adopting "populist-style" messaging, which focuses on themes of anti-elitism, people-centrism, and the preservation of national sovereignty. We highlight here three strands of such messaging that mirror our empirical tests. First, IOs can stress their connections with ordinary people—for instance, the non-elite backgrounds of their staff or leadership, which showcases their relatability. The Georgieva quote from the chapter's onset is illustrative. Similarly, IOs can spotlight initiatives that directly benefit ordinary citizens, such as job creation or public health projects, using simple and engaging language to make their messaging accessible.

Second, IOs can signal alignment with populist leaders who claim to represent "the common man." For example, tweets featuring photos of IO officials meeting with populist leaders and highlighting shared goals can create an impression of collaboration. By showing they are willing to work with populists, IOs can subtly counter the narrative that they are antagonistic to popular interests. For instance, NATO Secretary General Jens Stoltenberg tweeted about a productive meeting with Turkey's populist leader Recep